Richard

By Allie Brosh

NARRATOR: **(Pg 15+)** ***People: Where do they live? Us – Our House; Other People – Remote mystery houses that your mom drives you to.***

For the first few years of my life, the only people I knew how to find lived in my house. We had a neighbor, Richard. But Richard was quiet and rarely outside for long, so I didn't know about him. One afternoon, though, Richard went outside. That's how I found out about him. I just **saw** him. He probably didn't even know. He stood in his driveway for a minute or two and then went back into his house. But I **saw** him.

It was very exciting. A person lives next to us! A ***person****!* He lives right there! And I **SAW** him! When will he go outside again? What else does he do? Does he know about dad? Who is his friend? Does he like whales? Is his house the same as ours? ***Carpet – Could be brown like ours but could also be blue! Blue carpet! What if his walls are blue too? What if he has a different couch? Which room does his grandma live in? – Maybe [she] lives in the bathroom . . .*** Who knows what all the possibilities are!

INTRODUCTION

Let's face it: kids are total suckers. When we were young, we believed a lot of crazy things.

- *If you swallow watermelon seeds, an entire watermelon will grow inside you.*
- *Quicksand is everywhere, and you have to be constantly vigilant for it.*
- *Sharks are lurking in the deep end of every swimming pool. (beat)*
- *A person lives next to us!*

Yup . . . just part of being a kid. As we tried to make sense of the world, our imaginations often got the better of us. But in this selection imagination becomes action – weird, weird action!

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NARRATOR: Desperate to catch another glimpse of him, I'd lurk near the windows all day just staring at his house. I think I expected it go somewhere. You can't find out there's a person living right next to you and then never get any answers. Maybe if you're 100 and you know everybody, but not if you're 3. Not when it's the first stranger you know how to find. I just wanted to know more. **Anything.**

And the whole thing could have ended right here folks . . . and NOBODY would get any answers about Richard . . . if it wasn't for the dog door.

My grandma usually supervised me while my parents were at work. **"Supervised"** - If she hadn't seen me in a while, she'd check to make sure I still had all my fingers, but escaping wasn't a big concern. The doors were locked . . . but the dog door was the weak point in the fortress. I'd sneak out through the dog door and go stare at his house from the edge of our driveway, hoping this would summon him. When it didn't, I'd sneak a little closer. ***Maybe it'll work if I stand in*** **Richard's** ***driveway . . . or maybe I'll just go over to this little window . . .***

I started sneaking out more frequently. I started sneaking out at night. And the fact that I was ***sneaking*** seems to suggest I might've been at least partially aware that this type of behavior should be a secret, but I don't think I'd reached that crucial developmental turning point where you're capable of recognizing how creepy you're being.

However, on the night I found the cat door in Richard's garage, even my undeveloped, fish-level brain could sense that a boundary was about to be crossed. A tiny, instinctual trace of doubt—***This might be too weird of a thing to do . . .*** Of course, one of the main features of undeveloped, fish-level brains is poor impulse control, and before I could complete the thought, I was in Richard's living room.

Here I am . . . I did it . . . Wowee!!! I hadn't prepared for this possibility. I'd dreamed of it, sure. But I wasn't expecting it to ***HAPPEN***.

A concrete objective never emerged, but the missions became bolder and more frequent. I started bringing things back with me. Richard's things. They seemed valuable, somehow. A nonsensical collection of Richard's possessions slowly accumulated at the back of my toy drawer. This would prove to be my downfall.

Long before that, though, my mom noticed that I'd mysteriously disappear sometimes. She wasn't worried yet because she didn't think I knew how to get out of the house, but one day she asked me where I'd been. And I said: "Hanging out with Richard."

"Hanging out" was a misnomer—Richard had been hanging out by himself and I had been standing in his hallway just out of view—but this was concerning news for my parents. They didn't even know that I knew Richard, let alone that we'd been "hanging out." They went over and knocked on Richard's door and asked him about it. And Richard, who was still somehow unaware of all the hanging out we'd been doing, told them he didn't know anything about that.

MOM: So you've never seen this kid before . . .

RICHARD: No, I mean . . . seen? Yeah. But not . . it wasn't . . just in the yard and stuff.

NARRATOR: I imagine things were tense for a bit. But the clues piled up. I couldn't control myself. I took more things, bigger things. I also branched over into hiding things for Richard to find. Pretty rocks, pieces of string, letters I'd tried to write. At that age, I didn't know how to spell very many words, so the messages were fairly cryptic: ***the entire alphabet, followed by the word Mom and a drawing of the sun. Rampant scribbling.*** It must've come off like being haunted by a defective but well-meaning ghost.

The connection should have been obvious. But, when faced with a mystery like, "Where did my remote control go? Why is there a piece of paper with a child's handwriting on it hiding in the VCR? And how do these rocks keep getting in here?" almost no rational adult would jump to the conclusion "because a child has been sneaking in through my

cat door and leaving these for me to discover." Not even with clues. I don't know what theory Richard came up with to explain it . . .

RICHARD: POSSIBLE THEORIES – (1) These things have always been here and I never noticed them; (2) Paranormal activity; (3) I have a very proactive form of epilepsy, and this is what I do while I am having a seizure.

NARRTOR: The thing that finally blew my cover was stealing Richard's cat. Stealing it wasn't the original plan. The opportunity presented itself, I seized it. It was a strong animal. Getting it into the drawer was difficult. It lived in the drawer for a while. I don't know how long. Hours, probably . . . And now it is time for a quick fact about cats: cats aren't good secrets, because, under extreme duress, they have the ability to make a sound like: ***YAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAOAO*** My parents eventually realized the sound was coming from inside the house and located the source of it. They weren't expecting to find quite so many of Richard's things.

I don't know if they put the pieces together immediately or processed them individually as they came up—

MOM: F*irst of all, there's a cat in this drawer; How about that.*

DAD: *There appear to be a considerable number of objects under the cat. This one is a shoe.*

MOM: *This one is a piece of bread.*

DAD: *This one is a credit card bill. Huh . . . it's addressed to 'Richard The Neighbor . . .*

NARRATOR: [They were] inching closer to the truth with every clue until the ultimate answer to "What does 'hanging out with Richard' mean?" was revealed. There was more than enough evidence to answer the question. That's got to be a strange moment for a parent. There's this omnipresent fear of predators and monsters, and you just . . . you never quite expect to find out the monster is your kid. There's no Hallmark card for ***"Sorry we accused you of being a molester; we didn't realize our kid was sneaking into your house and stealing your spoons and animals and watching you while you sleep. We're really, really sorry."***

Looking at the objects, and the freaked-out cat, and my parents' confused faces, I realized that yeah, maybe this had been a weird thing to do . . . I felt like I should explain why I had done this, but I didn't know either. So we all just stood there, feeling weird about ourselves and each other. *(awkward beat)* The cat was stoked to be free, though.

And Richard was (and probably still is) a very kind man.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Allie Brosh
Book: Solutions and Other Problems, Pg 15
ISBN: 978-1982156947
Publisher: Gallery Books
Date (Month/Year): Gallery Books

AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier

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